Human-made Things in the Bible © United Bible Societies, 2025. Adapted from: The Works of Their Hands: Man-made Things in the Bible, by Ray Pritz © 2009 United Bible Societies. This work is licensed under Creative Commons Attribution-ShareAlike 4.0 International (https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-sa/4.0/).

Introduction

0.1 Introduction

Translating man-made things in the Bible

It was not long after people were created that they began to manufacture objects to make life easier and more enjoyable. Adam is barely out of the garden of Eden when we read that Jubal was "the ancestor of all musicians who play the harp and the flute," and that Tubal Cain "made all kinds of tools out of bronze and iron" (GEN 4:21, GEN 4:22; Good News Translation [GNT]).

The Bible mentions at least five hundred distinct objects manufactured by humans, and these can present a special challenge to the translator. While there is much that is common to all human experience, and basic material needs remain fairly constant, a number of factors can make it difficult to find the proper equivalent when translating a word for a particular material object. For example, raw materials vary widely, physical conditions may dictate different solutions to a common problem, and technology can differ greatly from one region to another and from one era to another.

The end result is that one present-day culture may not have a word for an object that was common in the lands of the Bible three thousand years ago, while another culture may have ten words for varieties of the same object. In the first case the translator needs to find a way to help the reader understand the meaning and significance of an unknown object; in the second case he or she will probably have to determine which variation of a known item is intended by the Scriptures.

Modern counterparts of ancient things may have changed so much that to use the modern word is to mislead the reader. It is important not to introduce anachronisms into the translation. For example, when rendering the writing implement "pen," the translator should not choose a word that in normal speech indicates a ballpoint pen. In cases where no word exists in a language for an equivalent object, there are several options. It may be possible to borrow a word from a regional or trade language. Another alternative is to expand the translation somewhat to describe the object or its function. For example, in AMO 7:7 the Hebrew text refers to a man as standing "... beside a wall built with a plumbline, with a plumbline in his hand" (so Revised Standard Version [RSV]), but the Contemporary English Version (CEV) expands this to "... beside a wall and holding a string with a weight tied to the end of it. The string and weight had been used to measure the straightness of the wall." An option open to Bible editions with annotations is to describe an object and its use in a footnote. Finally, it may be possible to include a glossary at the end of a Bible edition and explain difficult terms there.

In some cases, while a specific physical object is mentioned in the text, it is not essential to the understanding of the text. For example, the Hebrew expression "you will possess his gates" (see GEN 24:60) may be difficult in some cultures where walled cities with gates are unknown. However, there will be no loss of meaning if we render the clause as "you will capture his city." This kind of substitute is frequently possible when objects are used figuratively. The translator must be careful, however, not to eliminate the object too quickly but to check if some meaning or significance would be lost if it is replaced through rewording.

It can come as a surprise to find how often physical objects are used in a figurative or metaphorical sense in the Bible. The Greek word for "yoke," for example, appears five times in the New Testament, always figuratively. Translators must take care to ensure that a literal rendering of the material object will retain the same figurative sense in the receptor language. Where the figurative meaning would be obscured, it may be better not to mention the physical object and simply render the figurative meaning. For example, the statement of the angel to Mary in LUK 2:35 that "a sword will pierce your soul" (New Jerusalem Bible [NJB]) may be impossible in some languages. Since the focus is not on the physical object "sword," a translator may keep the meaning with "you will experience anguish" or find a similar idiom as the New English Bible (NEB) has done: "you ... shall be pierced to the heart."

This book is not intended to be a lexicon on the material culture of the Bible. For this you may use books like those mentioned in the Bibliography. The focus here is the translation task and we have endeavored to keep the needs of the Bible translator in view. For this reason there will normally not be a discussion of how a particular object came into being or the stages through which it developed before its appearance in Scripture. Similarly, the

dimensions of material objects are given only with a degree of precision that can help the translator to choose between different options in his or her own culture.

Illustrations

Most of the items discussed in this Handbook are accompanied by one or more illustrations. While it is recognized that the details of construction of many of the items changed or evolved over the course of the centuries covered by the Bible, it is not the purpose of this Handbook to document that evolution. Illustrations are included here to aid the translator to find the right word or phrase when translating specific Bible verses. In almost no case will the small changes in construction affect the choice of words to be used in a translation. Only where it is thought that this might be the case are different illustrations given showing those changes. Even in such cases, the differences between, for example, early Old Testament times and New Testament times are usually explained only in the written description of the item. Archaeology is constantly uncovering physical objects that throw new light on the material culture of the ancient world. Some of these discoveries change the accepted wisdom about how objects were constructed and used or when they made their first appearance in history. While the author has attempted to represent the current position among scholars, it is to be expected that some of the information will be outdated even before it is printed. It is hoped that the differences will have little adverse effect on the quality of translations.

Some of the illustrations are photographs of objects uncovered in archaeological excavations. While these have the advantage of showing real objects from Bible times, they are often less attractive than drawings or modern reconstructions.

Measurements

For some man-made objects in Scripture translations the dimensions are stated in units of measurement known in biblical times. In this Handbook we have sometimes given those original measurements and then converted them to their modern equivalents. A difficulty arises when converting the cubit, since varying lengths for the cubit were used at different times or in different contexts. While this inconsistency may influence the translation of the actual dimensions listed in Scripture, it will rarely affect the translation of the name of a material object. For that reason this Handbook consistently uses an approximate length for the cubit of fifty centimeters or twenty inches.

References

With each entry appears a list of transliterated Hebrew/Aramaic, Greek, or Latin words that represent the object being discussed. Following each word are listed references to biblical books. In most cases this reference list contains all of the verses where that particular word carries the meaning being discussed. In instances where a word appears more than about twenty or thirty times, the list only includes the first few places the word is used in the Bible followed by the + symbol indicating that there are more references.

The versification system used in most English translations has been taken as the basis for references listed or mentioned in discussion. This system occasionally differs from that found in the Hebrew Old Testament, the Septuagint, and some non-English translations. When that happens, the alternative versification is placed in parentheses.

The Hebrew lexicon of Brown, Driver and Briggs is the basis for the transliteration of Hebrew words. We transliterate the Hebrew roots they give, not the specific forms that occur in the text. In a few places some authorities may disagree with the root given.

Deuterocanon/Apocrypha

The United Bible Societies cooperate in translation projects with all churches, where possible. The majority of Christians in the world belong to churches that recognize as Holy Scripture those writings known by some as the Deuterocanon and by others as the Apocrypha. These books (their number differs between Catholic and Orthodox

churches) have been included in the listings and discussions of this Handbook. In some cases they introduce objects that are not mentioned in the sixty-six books of the Protocanon (for example, a fighting platform on a war elephant.) Where a Greek word appears both in the New Testament and the Deuterocanon, the New Testament references are given first, followed by the deuterocanonical references in brackets.